

The Power of PULP

Another formula book of cultural stereotypes from the master of middlebrow

By Antara Dev Sen



**2 STATES: THE
STORY OF MY
MARRIAGE**

by CHETAN BHAGAT

Rupa

Price: Rs 95

Pages: 269

Chetan Bhagat, a bestselling brand, doesn't need reviews. Besides, book reviews look at literary merit, which is irrelevant for Bhagat. Like in a dollar store, you can pick up any Chetan Bhagat book for Rs 95, the price of a cup of coffee in happening cafés. His books are accessible, supermarket-friendly and doomed to be bestsellers. So you could safely skip this page.

Still here? Okay, here goes. *2 States: The Story of My Marriage*, is an easy read, with funny moments and a storyline so simple that you want to protect it from the world. It presents the problems of Krish, a young IT and IIM-A grad, a Delhi Punjabi, in love with his classmate Ananya, a TamBrahm brainy babe from Chennai. In a way, it takes off from where Bhagat's first book *Five Point Someone* ends. It's also somewhat autobiographical. And has a refreshing disdain for correctness as it lustily embraces comical cultural stereotypes while gently disengaging itself from the demands of English grammar and style.

Krish, a meek and manipulative Punjabi, tackles life's problems one at a time, in tidy, short, reader-friendly episodes. Fortunately, he only has two problems in life: one, how to get Ananya's family to like him; two, how to get his own family to like Ananya. Naturally, beleaguered by raw and sensitive kin, Krish doesn't have a single friend—especially since friends have a nasty habit of increasing character count and distracting the reader with non-essentials.

2 States has an excel-sheet precision, balancing young love, parental pressures, youth aspirations, elementary social commentary, one-liners, self-improvement tips, new-age speak, and the manda-

tory mush, sex, toil and tears. All neatly gathered and offered like a Powerpoint presentation. As a formula book for the spoon-fed, young, English-reading masses, it's okay. Especially, if you skip the last chapter.

Slamming Chetan Bhagat for lack of literary value would be like scoffing at *bhelpuri* because it doesn't have *ghee*. Let's not make a category mistake. Popularity and literary excellence are not related (though they can be friends). You could, for example, enjoy Karan Johar films (no offence) without proclaiming him to be the next Mrinal Sen or Shyam Benegal.

Traditionally sneered at in all languages, popular and pulp fiction is nevertheless the mainstay of Indian literature. Bhagat dominates that segment in English. Has he changed Indian literature forever, as advertised? No. Popular fiction has always ruled the books market. Middlebrow authors in Indian languages have prospered while highbrow writers have slogged at day jobs and felt superior. Bhagat is special only as the most visible star in Indian popular fiction today—partly due to magnificent marketing, partly due to writing in English, an accessible, pan-Indian and international power language.

For more than a decade, we have moaned about youngsters losing the habit of reading. Our print media has repackaged itself in quick and reader-friendly avatars to grab the fleeting attention spans of distracted people in an aspirational society. Can we honestly grudge Chetan Bhagat his success? He is a management professional who has built his own brand without furiously promoting regressive values, and we should be happy that he has caught the flickering attention spans of college kids who may otherwise not be reading at all. The question of literary taste can only arise when there is a culture of reading. And with every new book Bhagat helps in developing that culture.

Oh yes, you could also read him for fun. (No offence.) ■



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